PARMIGIANO REGGIANO PDO



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Hardcooked
SUB MAKE:	Grana
POST-MAKE:	Wrapped, Rolled or Processed
SUB POST-MAKE:	Other Wrapped
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	12-36 months
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	38kg
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	Italy
PROTECTED STATUS:	PDO - must be made in the provinces of Parma, Reggio Emilia, Modena and areas of Mantua and Bologna
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
BREED OF COW:	Breeds not specified
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Raw cows' milk
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Animal
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

This grand Italian cheese, known as Parmesan in the UK, has been made for more than 900 years on the plains between the Rivers Po and Reno in Emilia Romagna. Produced with raw milk from cows that only eat grass and hay (no silage), the cheeses are matured for at least 12 months, but usually much longer. Made with partially skimmed milk, the curd is cut into small grains and scalded at 55°C. The curds settle beneath the whey and mass into a single block which is cut in half to yield two cheeses from each vat. The cheeses are moulded in a round, bottomless cheese mould , called a fascèra, and are pressed under their own weight, giving the distinctive shape of the final cheese. They are brined for about 24 days. During maturation the cheeses are brushed to promote rind formation. Traditionally, the waste whey was used to feed pigs, which were used to make Parma ham.

THE CHARACTER

Cheeses matured for over 18 months are given a red seal; over 22 months a silver seal; and over 30 months a gold seal. The older the cheese, the harder and more granular it becomes with an abundance of amino acid crystals. The flavour also becomes more intense, balancing fruity, floral, umami and dairy notes.

PERFECT PARTNERS:

Wonderful for grating over pasta, Parmigiano-Reggiano also deserves to take pride of place on a cheeseboard. Serve with powerful reds such as Barolo and Primitivo from Puglia.

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